

Group seeks to remember historic Pa. steel mill, site of deadly labor clash

HOMESTEAD, Pa. (AP) — Many longtime residents of southwestern Pennsylvania fondly remember the night sky glowing an orange red as sparks shot from steel mill blast furnaces and lava-like slag was dumped into heaps.

Most of the area steel mills are now closed, and the intense glow associated with the industry long gone.

But a group dedicated to preserving the region's steel history wants to establish a park and museum at the former U.S. Steel Homestead Works, the site of a deadly 1892 clash between steelworkers and security agents hired by mill operators.

Neon lights would give visitors an idea of how the furnaces appeared when they were fired up and interactive kiosks would dot the site.

"I want people to be able to imagine what it was like to be in the center of an intensely hot mill 150 years ago," said Augie Carlino, the head of the Rivers of Steel National Heritage Area.

The plan is far from fruition, but a recent report from the National Park Service and legislation introduced in the U.S. House will help the project's progression and could secure a national status for the site, he said.

According to history compiled by Rivers of Steel, the Homestead mill was built in 1879 on the Monongahela River. The mill grew along three miles of the riverfront and employed more than 200,000 workers during its 125-year life.

Thirteen years after it opened, the Homestead became known for one of the most notable events in the history of the labor movement.

A contract for the Amalgamated Association of Iron and Steel Workers expired on June 30, 1892, and skilled workers at the mill went on strike. Industrialist Andrew Carnegie ordered his partner, Henry Clay Frick, to break the union and reopen the mill at any cost, Carlino said.

On July 6, Frick tried to bring in 300 armed men from the Pinkerton Detective Agency by barge to occupy and restart the mill. It's unclear who shot first, but 13 hours later, seven workers and three Pinkerton agents were dead. Hundreds more were injured.

Pennsylvania Gov. Robert Emory Pattison sent in state militia troops to occupy Homestead for the next four months. Within seven years, 26 states passed laws against hiring outside guards during labor disputes.

Late last month, the National Park Service issued a report that recommended the remnants of the Homestead works and two of the furnaces located across the river be designated as a park service affiliate, to be owned and operated by a nonprofit agency.

The move would allow the sites to be eligible for federal funding, even though the government would have no role in its management.

"The Homestead works site is a symbol of a defining moment in steel making and in labor-management relations," Carlino said. "Something must be preserved."